with the building of the positional installations, but now you reproach me for dismantling them too slowly." It seemed that Kuznetsov's suggestion to dismantle the missiles before they could be inspected was fully implemented even before U Thant left Cuba on the evening of October 31. Khrushchev was eager to carry out his part of the bargain, no matter what. But he had a problem, and the name of that problem was Fidel Castro.[26]

In a major speech given on October 31, Castro rejected inspections and stated, as he had done in negotiations with U Thant, that the American insistence on inspections was meant to humiliate the Cuban government. He also mentioned "certain discrepancies" that had arisen between the Soviet and Cuban governments but said that he was not going to discuss them further so as not to give ammunition to enemies. The "discrepancies," continued Castro, should be discussed on the party and government levels, "because above all we must state that we are Marxists and Leninists and that we are friends of the Soviet Union." Those words were met with an ovation. In all but form, however, the speech was less a challenge to the Americans than to the Soviets and to Nikita Khrushchev personally.[27]